Seven Days in the Provinces: The Lulav, the Memory of the Temple, and the Road to Hoshana Rabbah

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On the morning of Tuesday, 29 September 2026 (18 Tishrei 5787), in every shul, the four kinds were lifted again. For most of us it has become the most natural thing in the world: every day of Sukkot, except Shabbat, we take the lulav and etrog with the hadasim and aravot, say the blessing, and wave.

It was not always so.

One day, or seven

The Torah says, "You shall take for yourselves on the first day" the four kinds, "and you shall rejoice before the L-rd your G-d seven days" (Vayikra 23:40). The Mishnah explains how this was kept while the Temple stood. In the Temple, the lulav was taken all seven days. In the rest of the country, it was taken on the first day only. After the Temple was destroyed, Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai ordained that the lulav be taken everywhere for seven days, in memory of the Temple (Mishnah Sukkah 3:12).

So every time we take the four kinds on a day of Chol HaMoed, we are doing something that, in Temple times, was done only in the Temple. The ordinary synagogue in Talpiot or Bayit VeGan, the balcony in Modiin, the dining room in a small town in the Galil: for seven days each of these becomes, in memory, the place before the L-rd.

A memory that is also a practice

Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai lived through the destruction. He could have told the people to mourn, and they did mourn. But one of the things he chose to do was to spread a practice of the Temple across the whole land. The people could not go up to the Temple; so, in a sense, the Temple's lulav would go out to the people.

This is one of the deep patterns of Jewish survival. What was once concentrated in one holy place is carried by every home. The memory is not only told. It is done, with the hands, every morning of the festival.

We live in a different time. We are back in the land, Jerusalem is rebuilt and full, and the Temple Mount is in sight of many of our balconies. But the Temple itself has not been rebuilt, and so we still take the lulav for seven days in memory. Each morning's waving is a small act of both gratitude and longing: gratitude for what has returned, longing for what has not yet.

Toward the seventh day

The days are moving. 18 Tishrei is the fourth day. Three more mornings of lulav remain, and the last of them is Hoshana Rabbah, when the hoshanot circle seven times and the willows are taken by themselves.

On the road to that day, it is worth noticing the four kinds while we still have them in our hands. The etrog that looked perfect on the first day now has a small bruise. The lulav's leaves are a little drier. The aravot, the most fragile of the four, are wilting, and some people replace them before Hoshana Rabbah. The set is aging with the week.

That too is part of the lesson. The mitzvah is not a museum piece. It is used, handled, shaken, carried to shul and back. By the seventh day it shows the wear of the whole festival, like a well-used siddur. The Temple lulav was taken in one place. Ours travels.

For the rest of the week

If you have not yet done so, take the lulav with a child or a guest who does not have one. Let them say the blessing. Show them how to grip it, how to face, how to wave. That, too, is Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai's ordinance at work: a practice once kept in one holy place, now passed from hand to hand.

And on Hoshana Rabbah, when we take up the willows by themselves, remember that the week of lulav was itself a memory of the Temple, kept alive by a teacher who chose to spread holiness outward when the center was lost.

For the table

1. In Temple times, the lulav was taken for seven days only in the Temple.
2. Everywhere else it was taken for one day.
3. After the destruction, Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai ordained seven days everywhere, in memory of the Temple.

Sources

- Vayikra 23:40 (taking the four kinds; rejoicing seven days)
- Mishnah Sukkah 3:12 (seven days in the Temple, one day elsewhere; Rabban Yochanan ben Zakkai's ordinance)

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